negative images of China. The Takshashila Institution's survey of China's role in the spread of the virus, conducted in April 2020, indicated that 67 per cent of the Indians surveyed blamed China for the pandemic. About 18 per cent thought that it was caused by Chinese biowarfare and 48 per cent thought that it was due to China's failure to stop the illegal trade in wildlife. The survey noted that Indians frequently used terms such as 'Chinese virus', 'Wuhan virus', and 'Made in China pandemic' to characterize the origins of the pandemic. Nearly 53 per cent did not think it was racist to use these terms. Rather, it was vital to do so, to ensure that China did not 'escape responsibility'. Two-thirds of respondents said that Beijing's response to the pandemic was 'draconian and opaque', though a third felt that it had done a good job since the outbreak. Fifty-six per cent regarded Chinese assistance to other countries cynically, as China's way of 'projecting power', and 19 per cent thought it should be doing more to help internationally given that it was responsible for the crisis.[85] The Congress politician Manish Tewari used his Twitter account to suggest that the 'CoronaVirus is a bio-weapon that went rouge [sic – rogue] . . . It is an act of Terror.' Kunal Purohit wrote in the *South China Morning Post* that many Indian social media posts about Covid-19 had 'xenophobic and racist undertones, including remarks mocking the diets of Chinese people'. Fake videos of Chinese government actions circulated and 'images of homeless people on the streets of Shenzhen were passed off as being dead bodies on the streets of Wuhan'.[86]

In the tragicomedy that is so often India–China relations, the Indian media, on 17 November 2020, ran a story about a pre-print of a paper submitted to the respected medical journal *The Lancet*. Three researchers seemingly from China – all three have Chinese names but one of the authors is from a US university – suggested that the 'Indian subcontinent' and specifically India and Bangladesh may have originally incubated the coronavirus in the summer of 2019, months before it arrived in Wuhan. A heatwave, diminishing water supplies, monkeys fighting over scarce water, subsequent animal-to-human transmission, poor healthcare systems, and 'imperfect' hygiene were posited as the causes. The animal-to-human